

Beyond clausal ellipsis: a Universal Grammar perspective on exceptive constructions

Abstract

We defend a phrasal, relational analysis of exceptive markers against clausal-ellipsis analyses (Vostrikova 2021; Seguin 2024). Universal Grammar, we argue, makes available one dedicated device for exception: a relational head — an Axial Part in a Double-Relator configuration (Franco 2024) — that subtracts the exception from a nominal restriction and surfaces as a PP. A language either grammaticalises such a head (Italian *tranne*, English *except*) or approximates exception with a Boolean coordinator plus negation (Italian *ma non*, English *but not*), which fails to enforce containment. Containment is therefore our central diagnostic: a marker that imposes it cannot be the Boolean periphrasis and must be relational. We define a true exceptive semantically — by containment, the Quantifier Constraint, and the inference flip — derive that cluster from domain subtraction plus exhaustification with no silent clause, and show that the markers enforcing it have relational, not coordinating, morphosyntax: oblique case on pronominal Grounds, the strict NPI *alcuno*, and *che* as a category-sensitive D-linker rather than a complementizer. We further argue that *a parte* and *oltre a* are exceptive-additive duals, exceptive under negation and additive elsewhere. The account extends to English (*but* versus *except*) and to a typology of exception spanning macro-variation (Spanish versus Italian) and micro-variation (northern versus Tuscan Italian), rebutting Vostrikova's conditional analysis and Seguin's diagnostics for a clausal *eccetto* while conceding genuine clausal 'reserve' Grounds as CP complements of the relational head.

Keywords: exceptive constructions, clausal ellipsis, Axial Parts, adpositions, Italian, comparative microvariation

1. Introduction

Exceptive constructions carve a *hole* in a quantified statement. When we say *every student but John attended*, we make a claim about all the students and then, in the same breath, remove one of them from its scope. English *but* and *except*, Spanish *excepto* and *salvo*, and Italian *tranne*, *eccetto*, and *salvo* all do this: they combine with a quantified host and subtract a specified exception from the set the quantifier ranges over. The construction has a recognisable behaviour, illustrated in (1).

- (1) a. *Every student but John attended the meeting.*
- b. *No student but John attended the meeting.*
- c. **Some student but John attended the meeting.*

Three properties stand out, and von Stechow (1993, 1994) made them the agenda for any theory of exception. First, the construction applies to a positive universal and to a negative universal alike, but with a systematic *flip* of what is inferred about the exception: (1a) conveys that John did *not* attend, while (1b) conveys that he *did*. Second, it is barred with a plain existential, as (1c) shows — the *Quantifier Constraint*. Third, the exception must belong to the set the quantifier is about — the *containment* inference — so that *#every boy but Mary came*, with Mary not among the boys, is anomalous in the way a contradiction is, not merely false. We take this cluster — containment, the Quantifier Constraint, and the inference flip — to *define* what a true exceptive is, and we treat the cluster as the empirical bar any analysis must clear (§3).

Our organizing hypothesis is a claim about Universal Grammar: about how that cluster is built. We propose that UG makes available a single dedicated device for exception, and that the device is *relational* in a precise sense. It is an Axial Part or Relational Noun — the same category as the *foot* of *the foot of the mountain* or the *exception* of *with the exception of* — which takes the quantifier’s restriction as its Figure and the exception as its Ground (Svenonius 2006), and subtracts the second from the first. Syntactically this device is adpositional: it projects a prepositional phrase, not a clause. A language either grammaticalises such a head, yielding a genuine exceptive marker (Italian *tranne*, *eccetto*, *salvo*; English *except*), or it does not, in which case it can only approximate exceptive meaning by a different route: stringing together a coordinator and a negation (Italian *ma non*, English *but not*). This Boolean route is an understudy, not the real thing. It mimics the truth conditions in simple cases, but, as §2 shows, it does not enforce containment, and so it does not belong to the class of true exceptives at all.

The wedge that separates the real exceptive from its understudy is *containment*, and it can be felt directly. *I saw all the mammals except the penguins* is odd, because penguins are not mammals and there is nothing to subtract; but *I saw all the mammals, but not the penguins* is fine, because two independent statements are merely being conjoined. The exceptive cares whether the exception is inside the domain; the coordinator-plus-negation does not. That single asymmetry, developed in §2.1, is the empirical *fulcrum* of the paper.

This recasts the much-discussed phrasal/clausal split (Hoeksema 1987, 1995; Potsdam & Polinsky 2019; Polinsky et al. 2024). On our view there are not two species of exceptive, one phrasal and one clausal. There is one relational exceptive, realised as a PP, and alongside it a Boolean periphrasis that is not an exceptive. What previous work has classified as a ‘clausal exceptive’ is, we argue, either the Boolean periphrasis (which lacks containment) or a relational head that happens to take a non-nominal Ground — a PP or a CP — through a linker, and not the residue of clausal ellipsis recovering a nominal exception.

Two claims must be kept apart. The first claim is that the relation between the quantified host (the Figure) and the exception (the Ground) is the same relational kind found in adpositional structures. The second is that the exceptive constituent is a phrase, not a reduced clause. These are logically independent — one could hold the first and deny the second — and we argue for them separately, marking at each step which evidence bears on which.

The argumentative spine is containment, and we are explicit about avoiding circularity, because the obvious worry is that we are defining a true exceptive as ‘a relational head’ and then concluding that

exceptives are relational. We do no such thing. We define the class *semantically*, by the cluster above, with no mention of morphosyntax. The empirical claim is then a correlation that has to be *demonstrated*, not stipulated: the markers that exhibit the semantic cluster — above all, that enforce containment — turn out to have relational morphosyntax (oblique case on pronominal Grounds, the absence of coordinator behaviour, etc.), whereas the markers that fail containment (*ma non*, *but not*) have the morphosyntax of ordinary coordinators. The correlation could in principle fail; we argue that it holds. Containment, thus, does double duty: it diagnoses membership in the exceptive class, and, because the Boolean periphrasis fails it, it forces any containment-enforcing marker onto the relational analysis.

Because the hypothesis is about how a single device is *realised*, it is in the first instance a claim about UG variation, and we develop it as one. It predicts variation of two kinds. Macroparametrically, languages divide according to whether their containment-enforcing markers admit a clausal/coordinating source in addition to the relational one; the division is detectable in the case borne by a subject-correlated exception — nominative where a clausal source is available, oblique where it is not — and it places Spanish and Italian on opposite sides (§5.1, §10). Microparametrically, varieties of one language differ in how far a single relational marker extends across host types, with no difference in its category, as northern and central Italian differ in the reach of *eccetto* (§8.1, §10). Neither kind of variation is a difference between a phrasal and a clausal exceptive; both are variation in the realisation and distribution of one relational head, which is what makes the typology of exception a study in comparative microvariation rather than a catalogue of construction types.

We engage the strongest opposing view, not the weakest. The Boolean-coordination analysis (Pérez-Jiménez & Moreno-Quibén 2012) is the understudy itself, and it is dispatched by the penguin test of §2.1. The *competitor* is the conditional clausal-ellipsis analysis of Vostrikova (2021), adopted for Italian *eccetto* by Seguin (2024). That analysis is *not* equivalent to ‘but not’: it derives containment and it is compatible with the negative inference. Our objection to it is therefore comparative and morphosyntactic, not that it fails to derive the meaning. We also delimit our own claim carefully: we do not deny that an exceptive marker can take a clausal Ground (Italian *salvo che non...*); we deny that the marker is a clausal coordinator and that nominal exceptions are recovered by ellipsis. The paper proceeds as follows. §2 lays out the two strategies and the containment diagnostic; §3 derives the defining cluster from subtraction plus exhaustification, with no silent clause; §4 presents the Double-Relator Model; §5 gives the Italian morphosyntax; §6 treats non-DP, multiple, and clausal Grounds; §7 extends the account to English *but* versus *except*; §8 confronts Seguin’s clausal diagnostics for *eccetto*

one by one; §9 separates additives from subtractives; §10 sets out the typology and the variation it predicts; §11 concludes.

2. Two strategies for exception

2.1 *The Boolean understudy and the penguin test*

Suppose a language expressed exception by stitching an adversative coordinator onto a negation — the strategy of English *but not* or Italian *ma non*. The result coordinates two independent propositions (‘I saw all the mammals’ and ‘I did not see the penguins’) and imposes no relation between them beyond conjunction. Such a periphrasis should be completely indifferent to whether the ‘exception’ belongs to the quantifier’s restriction, because nothing in it ever subtracts the exception from anything: the two propositions are simply asserted side by side. A true exceptive is not indifferent to this. It *enforces* containment, because subtraction is only defined when there is something to subtract. The contrast between indifference and enforcement is the diagnostic, and Italian, which keeps the two strategies morphologically distinct, displays it cleanly.

(2) Italian

- a. *Ho visto tutti i mammiferi allo zoo, ma non i pinguini.*
have.1SG seen all the mammals at.the zoo but not the penguins
‘I saw all the mammals at the zoo, but I didn’t see the penguins.’
- b. *#Ho visto tutti i mammiferi allo zoo tranne i pinguini.*
have.1SG seen all the mammals at.the zoo except the penguins
‘#I saw all the mammals at the zoo except the penguins.’

The Boolean periphrasis (2a) is fully acceptable. Penguins and mammals are distinct sets, the two propositions are independently coherent, and conjoining them yields a sensible, if slightly pedantic, message. The exceptive (2b) is anomalous, and the anomaly is not about the world (it can be perfectly true that I saw the mammals and not the penguins) but about the construction: penguins are not mammals, so they cannot be subtracted from the restriction *mammiferi*, and the sentence asks us to perform an undefined operation. The periphrasis is therefore not a true exceptive, and the marker that *does* enforce containment must be something other than a coordinator. This is the foundation of the

dichotomy we defend throughout: *ma non* and *tranne* are not two exceptives but an understudy and the real thing.

2.2 *Why a containment-enforcing marker is relational*

Containment removes the Boolean option, but it does not by itself decide between the two remaining analyses of a true exceptive: a relational head (our claim) and a conditional clausal source (Vostrikova's). As already said, the argument that the marker is relational is made in two steps, which we keep apart. The first step is semantic (§3): the relational head, feeding the independently motivated semantics of subtraction-plus-exhaustification, derives the full cluster — containment, the Quantifier Constraint, the flip — with no silent clause. The second step is morphosyntactic (§5, §7): the markers that enforce containment behave as adpositional heads — they assign oblique case to pronominal Grounds, they license the linker *che* with non-nominal Grounds, and they lack the syntax of coordinators. The correlation between the semantic cluster and relational morphosyntax is the empirical content of the UG hypothesis, and we state it so that it could be falsified: a containment-enforcing marker with unambiguously coordinating morphosyntax, or a non-containment marker with adpositional morphosyntax, would refute it.

2.3 *The alternative: the conditional clausal analysis*

The penguin test does not touch Vostrikova (2021), and it is worth seeing why, because hers is the analysis we are really arguing against. Vostrikova does *not* equate *except* with 'but not'. On her account the exceptive phrase hides a clause, and the meaning is conditional in shape. Take *every student except John came*. The exceptive contributes, roughly, that John is the *smallest* set with the following property: once we hold fixed the facts about who-other-than-John did what, and let only the facts about John vary, every student came. Two ingredients do the work. A *Conditional Leastness* condition picks the minimal exception — without it, any larger set containing John would also satisfy the description. And containment falls out, because for John to be a coherent value of this minimisation he must be a student to begin with: a non-student cannot be 'set aside' from the domain of students. The negation that yields 'John did not come' is internal to the elided clause, not contributed by a coordinator.

The upshot is that Vostrikova's analysis predicts the penguin contrast just as ours does — a non-member cannot be set aside, so *#every mammal except the penguins* is correctly excluded — and it is

compatible with the inference flip. Our case against it is therefore *not* that it fails to derive the meaning. It is comparative, and it has two parts. First, the relational analysis derives the same cluster more economically and with a transparent *mapping* between syntax and semantics: subtraction is a nominal operation and it is performed by a nominal head, with no clause posited and then deleted (§3). Second, and decisively, the *syntactic* implementation of the clausal analysis — the exception as the focus-fronted remnant of a deleted clause — collides with independent facts of Italian: the case borne by pronominal exceptions, the impossibility of preposition stranding, and the distribution of the linker *che* (§5). The economy point is suggestive on its own; the morphosyntactic point is what carries the weight.

2.4 The semantic home: subtraction plus exhaustification

The semantics we adopt for the relational head is not novel; it is the now-standard *distributed* analysis of exception, and its virtue here is precisely that it was developed independently of the syntactic debate. On this analysis the meaning of an exceptive sentence decomposes into two pieces working at two different levels (Gajewski 2008, 2013; Hirsch 2016; Crnič 2018; Mayr & Vostrikova 2023). Locally, inside the nominal, the marker is *purely subtractive*: it removes the exception from the quantifier’s restriction and returns the smaller set. Globally, at the propositional level, an exhaustification operator does the rest. This operator — call it *Exh* — is the silent counterpart of *only*, the same device independently posited to derive scalar strengthening (the step from *some* to *not all*); it asserts the prejacent and negates the relevant alternatives. The negative inference about the exception and the Quantifier Constraint both come from *Exh* and from a condition of *Non-Vacuity* on subtraction (Gajewski 2013; Fox & Spector 2018), not from anything inside the exceptive phrase.

This division of labour is exactly what the relational strategy needs. Subtraction is nominal and local, so it is performed by a DP-internal relational head; the propositional contribution is computed where propositions are computed, by an operator that the grammar needs anyway. Nothing in this requires a clause to sit inside the exceptive phrase. §3 shows, step by step, how a *Double-Relator* syntax feeds this semantics and how each of von Stechow’s three properties drops out.

3. Deriving the cluster without silent clauses

The premise behind every clausal analysis is that only a clause can interact with a quantifier’s domain in the way von Stechow’s properties require — that a mere phrase, lacking propositional structure, could never deliver containment, the Quantifier Constraint, and the flip. This section shows that the premise is false. Once the marker is purely subtractive and *Exh* is in the grammar (§2.4), each of the three

properties follows, and none of them needs a silent clause. We take them in turn, and we keep the exposition concrete, because the derivations are simpler than the surrounding literature sometimes makes them look.

3.1 Containment

Containment is the easiest of the three, because it is not really an extra stipulation at all: it is the precondition for subtraction to be defined. The relational marker combines, inside the extended nominal projection, with a Ground selected by its lower relator — a DP — and returns *the quantifier's restriction minus the exception*. For that output to exist, the exception has to be in the restriction to begin with. Removing the penguins from the mammals is not a small set; it is an undefined operation, and the sentence inherits the undefinedness as anomaly.

(3) Italian

- a. *ogni mammifero tranne i delfini*
every mammal except the dolphins
'every mammal except the dolphins'
- b. *#ogni mammifero tranne i pinguini*
every mammal except the penguins
'#every mammal except the penguins'

The contrast in (3) is the nominal-internal echo of (2b), and it has an exact and familiar parallel in the *partitive*. *Two of the dolphins* presupposes that the dolphins form a relevant whole from which two can be drawn; *two of the penguins*, in a context about mammals, is odd for the same reason (3b) is.

(4) Italian

- a. *due dei delfini*
two of the dolphins
'two of the dolphins'

- b. *#due dei mammiferi marini, cioè dei pinguini*
 two of.the mammals marine that.is of.the penguins
 ‘#two of the marine mammals, namely of the penguins’

Containment, in other words, is the nominal-domain analogue of the part–whole presupposition that partitives carry, computed in the very same local, DP-internal configuration (see Moltmann 1995, 1997). This matters for the larger argument in two ways. It shows that containment needs no propositional machinery — a part–whole relation between two nominal denotations is enough — and it shows, again, that the Boolean periphrasis cannot have it, because conjoining two propositions sets up no part–whole configuration at all. The marker that enforces containment is doing something partitive-like and nominal, not something clausal.

3.2 *The Quantifier Constraint*

The Quantifier Constraint is the property that has been pressed hardest against phrasal analyses — the objection being that a phrase cannot ‘know’ which quantifiers it may combine with. It can, once we make the subtractive semantics and Exh explicit. Let the marker subtract the exception M from the restriction P, returning the restricted property $P \setminus M$, which the host quantifier then takes as its first argument. The marker also makes available a set of *focus alternatives*, obtained by varying the exception: $P \setminus M'$, for alternative exception-sets M' . Exh exhaustifies over these. Two conditions familiar from the distributed semantics then do all the work: *Leastness*, which requires M to be the smallest set whose subtraction makes the host sentence true, and *Non-Vacuity*, which requires that the subtraction make a difference to the truth value at all (Gajewski 2008, 2013; Crnič 2018; cf. Fox & Spector 2018 on Non-Vacuity). Neither condition mentions a clause.

Run this with a *universal* host and it behaves perfectly. *Ogni studente tranne Gianni è venuto* asserts that every non-expected student came; that is, every member of $\text{STUDENT} \setminus \{\text{Gianni}\}$ came.

- (5) Italian
Ogni studente è venuto tranne Gianni.
 every student be.3SG come except Gianni
 ‘Every student came except Gianni.’

Now exhaustify against the alternatives ‘every student in $P \setminus M'$ came’, for the proper subsets $M' \subsetneq \{\text{Gianni}\}$, of which there is exactly one, the empty set — i.e. against the plain ‘every student came’. Leastness requires $\{\text{Gianni}\}$ to be the *smallest* exception that makes the sentence true; if Gianni had in fact come, then the empty exception would already suffice, and Leastness would be violated. So the system forces the conclusion that Gianni did *not* come. The negative inference is thus *derived*, not stipulated and not smuggled in through a hidden negation: it is what Leastness plus exhaustification deliver when the host is universal.

Run the same computation with a *plain existential* host and it collapses — and the collapse is the Quantifier Constraint.

(6) Italian

**Qualche studente è venuto tranne Gianni.*

some student be.3SG come except Gianni

‘*Some student came except Gianni.’

Here is why (6) is out. *Some student in $P \setminus \{\text{Gianni}\}$ came* is entailed by the plain *some student came* whenever the exception is not exhaustive — if some student came, then unless Gianni was the *only* one, some non-Gianni student came too. So subtracting Gianni makes no difference to the truth value: the sentence with the exception and the sentence without it stand or fall together. No non-trivial least exception is determined, and the subtraction is vacuous. Non-Vacuity is violated, and the structure is filtered out. The Quantifier Constraint, then, is not an arbitrary restriction that a phrase would have to *memorise*; it follows from the same semantics the field already assumes, given only that subtraction is performed *locally, on the nominal restriction* — which is exactly what the relational syntax encodes. No clause inside the exceptive phrase, and no dedicated exceptive operator, is needed.

A clausal analysis can of course also derive the Quantifier Constraint, but it does so by routing everything through a deleted clause; the relational-plus-Exh package derives it from the bare fact that you cannot non-vacuously subtract from a set an existential is merely sampling. In Double-Relator morphosyntactic terms, as we will see below, drawing a boundary inside a region presupposes a region with a fixed extent: the universal and negative-universal hosts supply such a maximal, saturated set, the existential does not, and the Non-Vacuity failure is the interpretive reflex of there being no fixed domain to partition.

3.3 The inference flip

The third property is the flip: the same marker yields opposite inferences about the exception under *every* and under *no*. On the clausal analysis this requires one silent negation to somehow produce contradictory results in the two environments — not impossible, but not transparent either. On our analysis it is automatic, because the polarity of the inference is contributed by Exh operating over the *restricted quantifier*, and it simply tracks the monotonicity of the host.

(7) Italian

- a. *Ogni ragazzo tranne Gianni è venuto.*
every boy except Gianni be.3SG come
'Every boy except Gianni came.' (inference: Gianni did not come)
- b. *Nessun ragazzo tranne Gianni è venuto.*
no boy except Gianni be.3SG come
'No boy except Gianni came.' (inference: Gianni came)

In (7a) the host is upward-entailing on its restriction, exhaustification against smaller exceptions forces Gianni out of the set that came, and we infer that he did not come — the derivation of §3.2. In (7b) the host *nessun* 'no' reverses the monotonicity: *no boy in $P \setminus \{\text{Gianni}\}$ came* is now the assertion, and exhaustifying against the alternative 'no boy came' forces Gianni to be the one who *did* come, since otherwise the larger statement 'no boy came' would already hold and $\{\text{Gianni}\}$ would not be the least non-vacuous exception. The marker contributes the very same subtractive meaning in both sentences; only the host's monotonicity has changed, and the inference flips with it. The relational-plus-Exh package gets the flip for free, and this closes the objection that a phrasal account is silent on von Steinhilber's properties.

3.4 The division of labour, and the phrasal/clausal debate

The three defining properties are now in hand, with no silent clause inside the exceptive phrase. Containment is the precondition for a defined subtraction (§3.1); the Quantifier Constraint is the Non-Vacuity filter on that subtraction (§3.2); the inference flip is the monotonicity of Exh over the restricted host (§3.3). The premise that only a clausal source can deliver this cluster is therefore false under the distributed semantics the field independently adopts. A clausal analysis *can* derive the cluster — we do

not dispute that — but only by locating a negation inside an elided clause and requiring that single silent negation to yield opposite inferences under *every* and *no*, and by positing clausal structure that is then deleted wholesale. The relational-plus-Exh package gets the flip for free and keeps subtraction where the morphology puts it: in the nominal domain. This is the substantive reply to the charge that a phrasal account cannot capture the core inferences. It also sets up the rest of the paper, which shows that the morphosyntax of the containment-enforcing markers is, independently of the semantics, the morphosyntax of relational heads — so that the two legs of the argument, the semantic and the morphosyntactic, converge on the same conclusion.

4. The Double-Relator Model

4.1 Architecture

The relational head we are positing does not float free; it sits in a small, well-studied piece of structure. The Double-Relator Model (Franco 2024; Franco & Schirato 2026) analyses complex adpositional expressions as transparent configurations in which an Axial Part or Relational Noun is flanked by two relational heads: a *higher relator* that links the Figure to the Axial Part, and a *lower relator* that links the Axial Part to the Ground.

(8) [Figure [p_upper [AxP/RelN [p_lower [Ground]]]]]

A spatial expression makes the configuration concrete. In *il lago ai piedi del monte* ‘the lake at the foot of the mountain’, the lake is the Figure, *piedi* ‘foot’ is the Axial Part naming a region of the reference object, and the mountain is the Ground; *a* spells out the higher relator and *di* the lower one (cf. Talmy 2000).

(9) Italian

il lago [a [i piedi [di [il monte]]]]

the lake at the foot of the mountain

‘the lake at the foot of the mountain’

The Axial Part here is not an ordinary noun. *Foot* in this use does not denote an object; it names a region defined relative to the mountain, and it shows the syntactic reflexes of that special status (cf. Svenonius 2006). Each relator, on this model, (p_upper and p_lower) externalises an elementary mereological predicate — inclusion ($\subseteq$) or its converse ($\supseteq$) (cf. Franco 2024) — and the claim we build on is that exception is one more instance of this same architecture, with subtraction in the place of plain zonal inclusion (Belvin and Den Dikken 1997).

4.2 The inclusion baseline

Two everyday constructions show the relators doing their basic work, and they give us the baseline against which exception is the marked, heavier case. *Partitives* express simple inclusion: in *due dei ragazzi* ‘two of the boys’, the lower relator *di* externalises the relation $\subseteq$ between the part and the whole. *Comitatives* express the converse, inverse inclusion: in *la mamma con i bambini* ‘the mother with the children’, *con* externalises $\supseteq$, adding the accompanying set to the Figure (Franco & Manzini 2017).

(10) Italian

- a. *due dei ragazzi*
two of.the boys
‘two of the boys’ (inclusion $\subseteq$: the two are among the boys)
- b. *la mamma con i bambini*
the mother with the children
‘the mother with the children’ (inverse inclusion $\supseteq$: the children accompany the mother)

We acknowledge that partitives and comitatives carry well-known complications — sortal restrictions, constraints on the embedded determiner, the polysemy of *con/with* — and we do not claim that $\subseteq$ and $\supseteq$ exhaust their semantics (cf. Link 1983). We claim only that these predicates supply the relational *scaffolding* on which finer interface conditions are then imposed; nothing in the exceptive analysis turns on resolving the partitive debates (Falco and Zamparelli 2019, Cardinaletti and Giusti 2016, among others).

4.3 Exclusion is morphologically heavier than inclusion

Inclusion links matter that is already there, and a single relator suffices; exclusion denies membership, and it needs more structure. The content of this claim is morphosyntactic, and that is the only sense in which we press it. Italian marks the asymmetry overtly. The comitative uses bare *con*, but its negative counterpart, the abessive ‘without’, recruits the heavier *senza*, which behaves like an Axial Part: it licenses a lower relator *di* with pronominal Grounds (*senza di te*, against simple *con te*), and it surfaces in the fully analytic *in assenza di* ‘in the absence of’.

(11) Italian

- a. *la mamma con i bambini / con me / *con di me*
the mother with the children / with me / with of me
- b. *la mamma senza i bambini / senza di me*
the mother without the children / without of me

The extra *di* in *senza di me*, absent from *con me*, is the morphological trace of the heavier exclusion structure. The same asymmetry recurs crosslinguistically, with abessives systematically heavier than comitatives (Stolz et al. 2006, 2007). We offer the mereotopological intuition (that delineating an *excluded* region is structurally costlier than linking *included* matter) as background motivation for this robust morphological generalization.¹

4.4 Analytic exceptives: the transparent case

The clearest evidence for the bipartite relational structure of subtractive exceptives comes from the analytic markers, where the Axial Part is an overt Relational Noun and both relators can be pronounced.

(12) Italian

¹ While we formalize subtraction via the distributed semantics of Exh, this operation maps transparently onto the mereotopological intuition of ‘zonal exclusion’ (Franco 2024; cf. Varzi 2007). While an inclusion relator simply links existing entities, subtraction requires delineating a boundary within a maximal set — topologically, creating a ‘hole’. This cognitive asymmetry explains the robust cross-linguistic generalization that subtractive markers recruit structurally ‘heavier’ Axial Parts to draw that boundary, rather than simple P-heads.

- a. *tutti i mammiferi ad eccezione dei gatti*
all the mammals to exception of.the cats
'all the mammals with the exception of the cats'
- b. *tutti i funghi, all'infuori dei marzuoli*
all the mushrooms to.the outside of.the march.mushrooms
'all the mushrooms except the March mushrooms'²

In *ad eccezione di*, *a* spells out the higher relator, *eccezione* the Relational Noun, and *di* the lower relator — exactly the template of the locative *ai piedi di* in (9). The constituent is a nominal extended projection: there is a relational noun, a determiner-like layer, and two case-like relators, and nothing in it forces a CP, a TP, or a vP. We grant that the *absence* of clausal structure is a claim and not a brute fact; it is supported by the transparently nominal morphology of (12) and by the diagnostics of §5, not simply asserted.

4.5 Grammaticalised Axial Parts

The monomorphemic markers *tranne*, *eccetto*, *salvo* are the grammaticalised counterparts of the analytic forms. They spell out the whole skeleton in one piece³ and license null realisations of the relators — the same alternation we see across Italian spatial Ps, where *sotto il tavolo* 'under the table' alternates with the fuller *sotto al tavolo*, with and without an overt lower relator.

(13) [Tutti i ragazzi [p_upper Ø [AxP *tranne* [p_lower Ø [Ground Gianni]]]]]

² The analytic marker *all'infuori di* provides the most transparent morphological evidence for the DRM skeleton. It visibly decomposes into the upper relator 'a' (fused with the determiner 'i'), the directional prefix 'in-', the spatial Axial Part 'fuori' ('outside'), and the lower relator 'di' ('of'). The grammar overtly stacks adpositional/relational heads to construct the exclusion boundary, laying bare the spatial origin of the exception with no plausible clausal source

³ From a theoretical perspective, the grammaticalization of monomorphemic exceptive markers (such as Italian *tranne* or *eccetto*) can be captured through the mechanism of phrasal spell-out, build within the Nanosyntactic framework (Starke 2009; Caha 2009). While standard approaches lead to postulate phonologically silent functional heads (Ø) for the unpronounced upper and lower relators (cf. Kayne 2005), phrasal spell-out allows a single, grammaticalized lexical item to spell out a complex syntactic spine. Under this view, the diachronic process of grammaticalization — whereby complex, multi-word locutions crystallize into dedicated exceptive markers — can be formalized as a lexical item expanding its spell-out domain. As the AxP grammaticalizes, it absorbs the *p_upper* and *p_lower* relational nodes into a single portmanteau spell-out, effectively internalizing the bipartite relational architecture without deleting the syntactic structure itself.

(14) Italian

- a. *sotto il tavolo*
under the table
- b. *sotto al tavolo*
under to.the table
'under the table'

The alternation in (14) is uncontroversially adpositional (cf. Rizzi 1988, Tortora 2005, Folli 2008), and *tranne Gianni* relates to *ad eccezione di Gianni* as (14a) relates to (14b): the same relational structure, with the relators silent in the grammaticalised variant. The etymologies are consistent with this status — *tranne* from *tra* *ne* 'extract from it', *eccetto* from *exceptum* 'taken out', *fuorché* from *fuori* 'outside' + *che* — and we note them as suggestive support, not as proof, since a diachronic source does not by itself fix a synchronic category.

5. Italian morphosyntax: a relational head, not a coordinator

The semantics of §3 shows that a phrase *can* deliver von Stechow's cluster. This section makes the positive morphosyntactic case that, in Italian, the marker *is* a phrase — specifically, a relational head selecting a complement — and not a coordinator joining clauses. We give four arguments for a phrasal account.

5.1 Oblique case on pronominal Grounds

If the marker coordinated clauses, and the exception were the surviving subject of an elided clause, then a subject-correlated exception ought to bear *nominative* case — the case a subject gets. It does not. With a subject correlate, Italian licenses *oblique* case.

(15) Italian

- a. *??*Tutti hanno giocato tranne/fuorché io.*
all have.3PL played except I.NOM

- b. *Tutti hanno giocato tranne/fuorché me.*
 all have.3PL played except me.OBL
 ‘Everyone played except me.’

Oblique case on a tonic pronoun is the canonical signature of a prepositional or relational head (Svenonius 2007): it is the case we see in *con me* ‘with me’, *per te* ‘for you’, *senza di me* ‘without me’. A defender of the clausal analysis has a rejoinder ready: perhaps the oblique is the case of an *object* in the elided clause, not of a subject. An unergative verb closes that escape, because an unergative has only an external argument — a subject — and no internal-argument position for the pronoun to occupy.

(16) Italian

- a. **Hanno nuotato tutti tranne io.*
 have.3PL swum all except I.NOM
- b. *Hanno nuotato tutti tranne me.*
 have.3PL swum all except me.OBL
 ‘Everyone swam except me.’

Nuotare ‘swim’ is unergative, so the exception in (16) can only correspond to the subject of an elided *io non ho nuotato* ‘I did not swim’, whose pronoun is nominative *io*. The standard assumption behind clausal stripping is *case-matching*: a remnant bears the case of its correlate (Merchant 2004). Case-matching predicts nominative *io*; Italian requires oblique *me*. The only available rejoinder is to abandon case-matching for these structures and appeal to *default* case — and Italian’s default tonic form does happen to be oblique-shaped. The rejoinder is coherent, but it is costly, and the cost is exposed the moment we look at Spanish, where the very same configuration yields nominative.

(17) Spanish

- Nadaron todos excepto yo.*
 swim.PST.3PL all except I.NOM
 ‘Everyone swam except me.’

The minimal pair (16b)/(17) is the heart of the argument: Italian licenses oblique *me* exactly where Spanish licenses nominative *yo*, in the same construction, with the same unergative host, and the same subject correlate. Case-matching predicts the Spanish nominative directly — it is read off the subject of the elided clause (cf. Bittner and Hale 1996). A uniform clausal analysis must then say that Spanish obeys case-matching while Italian (mysteriously) switches to default case — an unprincipled stipulation precisely where the two languages differ. The relational analysis predicts the contrast without stipulation: Spanish markers admit a clausal/coordinating source (Pérez-Jiménez & Moreno-Quibén 2012), so the remnant takes nominative from an elided finite T, whereas Italian markers are relational, so the Ground takes oblique from the lower relator, exactly as in *con me*. The case contrast is thus a diagnostic of the categorial split itself, placing Italian *tranne/eccetto* on the relational side and Spanish *excepto/salvo* (at least optionally) on the clausal side, in line with Potsdam & Polinsky (2019). We present the bare Italian oblique as strong but not decisive in isolation; the most important step is the Spanish contrast.

A note on the Spanish *datum*, since the macroparameter rests on it. That subject-correlated exceptive remnants take nominative in Spanish is the prescriptively sanctioned pattern and the one reported in the descriptive and theoretical literature: the Real Academia treats *excepto*, *salvo*, and *menos* as conjunction-like elements that leave a following subject pronoun in the nominative (*Vinieron todos excepto yo/tú*, not ...*excepto mí/ti*), and Pérez-Jiménez & Moreno-Quibén (2012) build their Boolean-Phrase analysis on exactly this property. Colloquial Spanish admits oblique *excepto mí* for some speakers, but the diagnostic is the *availability* of the nominative parse, which Spanish has and Italian categorically lacks: to our knowledge, there is no register of Italian in which **tranne io* is licensed/preferred. The contrast is therefore not gradient prescriptivism but a categorial split — nominative available versus oblique — and it is the visible reflex of the macroparameter (see §10): the Spanish marker admits a clausal/coordinating source feeding nominative from a finite T, the Italian marker does not.

5.2 The strict NPI *alcuno*

A pillar of the conditional analysis is a negation *internal to the elided clause*. If that negation is really there, it should license negative polarity items inside the exceptive phrase, just as an ordinary clausal negation does. Italian provides an unusually sharp test, because the singular determiner *alcuno* is a *strict* NPI: unlike English *any*, which is licensed in any downward-entailing or merely non-veridical context, *alcuno* is licensed only by a *clause-mate sentential negation*.

(18) Italian

- a. *Non ho visto alcuno studente.*
not have.1SG seen any student
'I didn't see any student.'
- b. *??Se vedi alcuno studente, chiamami.*
if see.2SG any student call.me
'If you see any student, call me.'

The contrast in (18) fixes the diagnostic: clause-mate *non* licenses *alcuno* (18a), but the mere downward-entailing environment of an *if*-clause does not (18b). Now embed *alcuno* in the exception of a positive-universal exceptive. If that exceptive contained a hidden sentential *non* — as the conditional analysis needs — *alcuno* should be licensed. It is not.

(19) Italian

- **Ho visto tutti i miei amici eccetto alcuno studente.*
have.1SG seen all the my friends except any student
'I saw all my friends except any student.'

The ungrammaticality of (19) shows that there is no clause-mate sentential negation inside the exceptive phrase. (The licensing of English *any* in the corresponding configuration is then no embarrassment: *any* is the weak NPI, licensed by the downward-entailing environment that domain subtraction itself creates — Gajewski 2008 — consistent with §3, whereas *alcuno* demands the stronger, strictly clausal licenser that simply is not present). This argument is robust, because it rests on an independently established strict-NPI diagnostic that has nothing to do with exceptives.

5.3 *che* is a linker, not a coordinator's complementizer

When the Ground is not a bare nominal, Italian may dress it with *che*: alongside *tranne con Luca* one finds *tranne che con Luca* 'except with Luca'. A clausal analysis must read this *che* as the complementizer heading an elided clause. We argue instead that it is a generalised *D-linker* — a category-neutral element that dresses a non-nominal constituent so that a nominal-selecting head can

take it (Manzini & Savoia 2003, 2011; Kayne 2010) — and the distribution of *che* across Ground types is exactly what a linker, and not a complementizer, predicts. First, genuine coordinators *reject* a *che* that would introduce a coordinate clause.

(20) Italian

- a. **Piove e che fa freddo.*
rains and that makes cold
- b. **Piove ma che fa freddo.*
rains but that makes cold

The exceptive markers behave differently, and in a way that tracks the *category* of the Ground rather than the presence of a clause: with a PP Ground *che* is *optional*, with a bare DP Ground it is *barred*, and a true coordinator bars it throughout.

(21) Italian

- a. *Ho parlato con tutti ... ma non (*che) con Gianni.*
have.1SG spoken with all but not (that) with Gianni
'I spoke with everyone ... but not with Gianni.' (coordinator: *che* barred)
- b. *Ho parlato con tutti ... tranne (che) con Gianni.*
have.1SG spoken with all except (that) with Gianni
'I spoke with everyone ... except with Gianni.' (PP Ground: *che* optional)
- c. **Sono venuti tutti eccetto che Maria. / *ad eccezione di che Maria*
be.3PL come all except that Maria / to exception of that Maria (bare DP Ground: *che* barred)

This three-way pattern is the signature of a linker (Franco et al. 2015, Manzini et al. 2019). A coordinator bars *che* outright (21a), so the exceptive, which *permits* it on a PP Ground (21b), is not a coordinator. But the decisive contrast is (21c). If *che* were the complementizer of an elided exceptive clause, then *eccetto che Maria* — *che* plus a fronted remnant *Maria* plus an elided TP *non è venuta* — ought to be well-formed. Actually, it is sharply ungrammatical. The linker analysis predicts this directly: a bare DP already carries the D-features the lower relator selects (cf. Svenonius 2007) and so rejects the dressing *che*, whereas a PP, lacking them, optionally takes it. The complementizer analysis

has no comparable account of why *che* should be impossible precisely where the remnant is a bare nominal. Second, the same *che* links phrases in comparatives, where no one posits a hidden clause.

(22) Italian

Gianni è più ricco che saggio.

Gianni is more rich than wise

'Gianni is more rich than wise.'

The comparative *che* in (22) links two adjectives — like categories — without projecting a clause, and the exceptive *che* links *unlike* ones (a relational head to a PP Ground). This is the profile of a category-neutral linker: a coordinator must respect category identity, whereas a linker need not, which is why one and the same *che* can glue *ricco* to *saggio* and *tranne* to *con Luca*. Third, when the Ground genuinely is a clause, *che* is obligatory, surfacing as the dressing on that clause.

(23) Italian

Verrò, salvo che non piova.

come.FUT.1SG except that not rain.SBJV.3SG

'I'll come, unless it rains.'

The picture that emerges is a single linker with a category-sensitive distribution — barred on a bare DP (21c), optional on a PP (21b), obligatory on a CP (23) — exactly as a head that dresses non-nominal Grounds to satisfy nominal selection should behave, and quite unlike a complementizer, which the clausal analysis would expect wherever an elided clause sits. We return to the CP Ground of (23) in §6.3; here it shows only that *che* attaches to Grounds of more than one category, as a linker does and a coordinator's complementizer does not.

5.4 No preposition stranding, no P-erasing

The final argument turns on *preposition stranding* — the operation, allowed in English (*who did you talk to* __) but barred in Italian, of moving the complement of a preposition and leaving the preposition behind. Consider the bare-DP exceptive *Ho parlato con tutti tranne Carla* 'I spoke with everyone except Carla'. On a clausal derivation, the exception *Carla* is the focus-fronted remnant of an elided

clause ... *non ho parlato con Carla* ‘I did not speak with Carla’. But to surface as the bare DP *Carla*, the pronoun would have to move out of the PP *con Carla* inside that clause, stranding the preposition *con* — and Italian does not strand prepositions.⁴

(24) Italian

- a. *Ho parlato con tutti tranne Carla.*
have.1SG spoken with all except Carla
‘I spoke with everyone except Carla.’
- b. **Ho parlato con tutti tranne [Carla [con ___]].*
(putative clausal source: ... *tranne [Carla]_i [non ho parlato con ____i]*)

To make the clausal derivation of (24a) work one must either strand *con* — illicit in Italian — or stipulate a P-erasing operation that deletes the preposition and so weakens the identity condition on ellipsis. The relational analysis incurs neither cost: it selects the Ground *Carla* locally, with no movement out of a PP and no preposition to strand or erase (cf. Ranero 2021). We are careful here to state the point narrowly. Consider the example in (25).

(25) Italian

- Ho parlato con Maria, ma non con Gianni.*
have.1SG spoken with Maria but not with Gianni
‘I spoke with Maria, but not with Gianni.’

In (25) the PP *con Gianni* survives intact as a stripping remnant, preposition and all; nothing about Italian bars PP remnants as such. The asymmetry that matters is narrower and sharper: the *bare-DP* exceptive (24a) would, on a clausal source, require stranding, which Italian forbids — whereas the relational head derives it with no movement at all. And when the Ground genuinely *is* a PP, the

⁴ Note that for the majority of our native consultants, the bare DP exception in (24a) is fully acceptable. However, for other speakers, (24a) is slightly degraded and the matching of the preposition is favoured. Actually, a clausal-stripping analysis for speakers who require P-matching is ruled out by the linker ‘che’ (§5.3): true stripping rejects complementizers (‘ma non (*che) con Carla’), whereas the strict-matching exceptive freely admits the D-linker (‘tranne (che) con Carla’), confirming its relational rather than clausal-stripping nature.

exceptive does not strand either; it keeps the preposition and adds the linker (*tranne che con Gianni*, §5.3). We grade this argument as adequate rather than decisive on its own: it tells against the *bare-DP* clausal derivation specifically, and it converges with the linker *che* of §5.3, which ordinary stripping never licenses.

6. Non-DP, multiple, and clausal Grounds

So far the Ground has been almost always a plain DP. The arguments most often raised *for* a clausal source involve Grounds that are not plain DPs — prepositional remnants, multiple remnants, and clauses. We take them in turn, and in each case the same relational head, allowed to select Grounds of more than one category, handles the data without a deleted clause.

6.1 PP Grounds and the apparent type mismatch

Vostrikova’s strongest *semantic* argument against a phrasal source comes from prepositional remnants. Consider *I met a student from every city in Spain except from Barcelona*. The remnant *from Barcelona* is a PP, and, Vostrikova reasons, a phrasal exceptive would have to subtract the meaning of that PP from the nominal domain *cities* — but a PP-meaning is the wrong type to subtract from a set of cities, so the operation is ill-defined. The conclusion is that *from Barcelona* must be what survives an elided clause (... *except I met a student from Barcelona*), where it is type-appropriate.

(26)

- a. *I met a student from every city in Spain except from Barcelona.*
- b. *Ho conosciuto uno studente di ogni città della Spagna tranne (che) di Barcellona.*
have.1SG met a student of every city of.the Spain except (that) of Barcelona
‘I met a student from every city in Spain except from Barcelona.’

The argument has force only if the subtraction is required to target the bare nominal *cities*. It is not. The quantified antecedent already contains the *matching prepositional restriction* — *from every city* — and it is over those matching prepositional entities that the relational head computes subtraction. *From Barcelona* is removed from the domain *from every city*: a like-from-like operation, perfectly defined, and requiring no clause (where two restrictions are simultaneously at issue, the subtraction is over ordered pairs, by the polyadic mechanism of §6.2).

6.2 Multiple remnants and the asyndeton asymmetry

The headline argument for clausal ellipsis is the *multiple* exception, because the two pieces left behind do not form an ordinary constituent.

(27)

- a. *Every boy danced with every girl except John with Mary.*
- b. *Ho visto i ragazzi, salvo Carlo, Mauro e Valerio.* Italian
have.1SG seen the boys except Carlo Mauro and Valerio
'I saw the boys, except Carlo, Mauro and Valerio.'

In (27a), *John with Mary* is not a constituent of the usual kind, which seems to demand a clause (... *except John danced with Mary*). The response is to recognise that matrices like (27a) are *polyadic*: the quantifier binds two variables at once, ranging not over individuals but over pairs — here, over BOYS $\times$ GIRLS (Moltmann 1995). The exception is then the pair $\langle$ John, Mary $\rangle$, subtracted from that product, and the relational head takes the pair as its Ground; no biclausal derivation is needed, and polyadic quantification is in any case independently required for these matrices. A further contrast actively favours the relational analysis.

(28) Italian

- a. *Ho visto i ragazzi, salvo Carlo, Mauro *(e) Valerio.*
have.1SG seen the boys except Carlo Mauro *(and) Valerio
'I saw the boys, except Carlo, Mauro and Valerio.'
- b. *Gianni mangia molto, salvo al mare, coi colleghi.*
Gianni eats a.lot except at.the seaside with.the colleagues
'Gianni eats a lot, except at the seaside, with colleagues.'

When the multiple exceptions are *discrete individuals*, they must be assembled into a single conjoined DP, with obligatory *e* 'and' (28a): the asyndetic **salvo Carlo, Mauro, Valerio* is out. But when they are *event modifiers* — a locative and a comitative — they stack freely, with no coordinator, as the independent adjuncts they are (28b). A uniform clausal analysis would have to derive (28b) from several unpronounced clauses with several extractions, which overgenerates badly (cf. Reinhart 1991). We do not claim that (28a) decides the issue — a clausal analysis could derive it by raising a conjoined

object — but the *asymmetry* between (28a) and (28b) falls out naturally from a relational syntax in which DP Grounds and event-modifier Grounds differ in their internal make-up, and does not from a uniform clausal source.

6.3 CP Grounds: clauses of reserve

Italian does have a genuinely clausal exceptive-like construction, the *subordinata di riserva* ‘reserve clause’ (Bianco 2010).

(29) Italian

Il concerto salterà, salvo che non smetta di piovere.

the concert jump.FUT.3SG except that not stop.SBJV.3SG of rain.INF

‘The concert will be cancelled, unless it stops raining.’

We concede without hesitation that the Ground in (29) is a clause. But conceding a *clausal Ground* is not conceding a *clausal coordinator*, and it is certainly not conceding that *nominal* exceptions are clausal. The reserve clause is a CP selected by the same relational head that elsewhere selects a DP — and the model for this is entirely ordinary, because relational heads routinely select either a DP or a CP, choosing a linker accordingly. The temporal adpositional head *prima* ‘before’ is the clearest case.

(30) Italian

a. *prima della pioggia*

before of.the rain

‘before the rain’

b. *prima che piova*

before that rain.SBJV.3SG

‘before it rains’

The single head *prima* takes a DP Ground through the relator *di* (30a) and a CP Ground through the linker *che* (30b), with no suggestion that (30b) is a coordination or that (30a) is derived from it by ellipsis. The reserve clause *salvo che non...* stands to *salvo* + DP exactly as *prima che piova* stands to *prima della pioggia*: one relational head, two Ground types, two linkers. Two facts confirm that this is

selection and not coordination. True coordinators bar *che* (20), whereas *salvo* requires it; and the reserve construction has the eventive, conditional reading appropriate to a CP Ground that denotes a situation. The existence of *salvo che non...* is therefore *predicted* by a relational head that admits Grounds of more than one category — it is not a counterexample to the phrasal analysis, and it is not clausal ellipsis recovering a nominal exception.

6.4 Situational Grounds and silent eventive quantifiers

A second clausal-looking case turns out to follow from the same logic and to confirm it. The English pair *John sleeps well except when Mary snores* / *except that he snores* has an Italian counterpart with a clausal Ground.

(31) Italian

a. *Gianni dorme bene tranne quando Maria russa.*

Gianni sleeps well except when Maria snores

‘John sleeps well except when Mary snores.’

b. *Gianni dorme bene salvo che russi.*

Gianni sleeps well except that snore.SBJV.3SG

‘John sleeps well except that he snores.’

The key observation is that the host here is not a nominal restriction at all, but a *silent universal quantifier over situations*: *Gianni dorme bene [in ogni circostanza] tranne quando Maria russa* ‘John sleeps well [in every circumstance] except when Mary snores’. This covert quantification over situations is not *invented* for the exceptive; it is the very domain that adverbs of quantification manipulate (Lewis 1975; cf. von Stechow 1994). The exception is then the *set of situations* in which Mary snores, and the relational head subtracts that set from the domain of circumstances exactly as it subtracts an individual from a nominal restriction. The Ground is a CP — a temporal/adverbial clause introduced by *quando* or by the linker *che* — selected by the relational head, and not a second coordinated proposition. The construction is the *situational analogue* of nominal exception, with *zonal exclusion* applying to an eventive domain rather than an entity domain, precisely as in the reserve clause of §6.3.

Two diagnostics show this is relational subtraction and not clausal coordination, and they are, tellingly, the very two that separate the true exceptive from its Boolean understudy throughout the paper. First, *containment holds in the situational domain*: the excepted situations must be a subset of the quantified circumstances, just as *#ogni mammifero tranne i pinguini* fails because penguins are not mammals. A coordinator of independent propositions would impose no such condition; the marker does. Second, true coordinators reject the linker (20), whereas *tranne/salvo* require *che/quando* — the signature of a relational head selecting a CP Ground. A datum offered as possible evidence for clausal coordination thus turns out to instantiate the predicted CP-Ground option of a single relational head, restricting a silent eventive universal. For completeness we flag the available clausal rejoinder — that the silent situational domain simply *is* the elided clause — and note that it is answered by these same two facts: a coordination predicts neither the situational containment condition nor the obligatory *che*.

7. English: but versus except

English lexicalises the relational strategy *twice*, with different degrees of grammaticalisation, and the contrast supports the dichotomy rather than undermining it. The tempting map — *but* as the Boolean/clausal marker, *except* as the relational/phrasal one — is wrong. Both are relational; the difference is that *but* is the more tightly connected, more nominalised variant, and *except* the freer one. The connected marker *but* clings to its quantified host, is restricted to universal and negative hosts, resists prepositional and clausal Grounds, and shades into the exclusive focus particle *only* (*nothing but trouble* ≈ ‘only trouble’).

(32)

- a. *everyone but John / nothing but trouble*
- b. *?everyone but from John*
- c. **everyone but that he snores*

The free marker *except* fronts, takes PP and CP Grounds, and even hosts a speaker-oriented adverb.

(33)

- a. *Except for John, everyone came.*
- b. *I got no presents except from my mom.*
- c. *John sleeps well except that he snores / except when Mary snores.*

- d. *Everyone will come except possibly Ann.*

The hard case for *any* analysis is that *except* enforces containment — and yet takes a CP Ground. Containment is easy to verify: *except* patterns exactly with Italian (2b)/(3b).

(34)

- a. *every mammal except the dolphins*
- b. *#every mammal except the penguins*

Because *except* enforces containment (34b), it cannot be the Boolean periphrasis: *except* is not *but not*. So *except* must instantiate the relational strategy — and its CP complement in (33c) is therefore a CP Ground selected by the relational head through the linker *that*, the English counterpart of the reserve clause *salvo che...* (§6.3) and of the situational construction *except when Mary snores*, which restricts a silent eventive universal (§6.4), and exactly parallel to temporal *before [that it rains]* (30). It is not clausal ellipsis recovering a nominal exception. The PP Ground in (33b) is licensed the same way, by category selection (here, *except from*), not by a deleted clause.

The *but/except* asymmetry now falls into place. *But* resists PP Grounds (32b) because it is the more *grammaticalised*, connected Axial Part, with residual restrictions that the freer *except* lacks; this is a difference of *degree of nominalisation within the relational class*, not a categorial split between a coordinator and an adposition. We suspect that the historical syncretism of English *but* — adversative coordinator and exceptive in one form — is the very source of the field’s bias toward clausal-coordination analyses. Romance segregates the two functions morphologically (*ma (non)* versus *tranne/eccetto*), which makes the relational nature of the true exceptive transparent in a way that the English lexicon hides.

The most resilient pro-clausal datum is the speaker-oriented adverb in (33d), *except possibly Ann*, on which Mayr & Vostrikova (2023) build a clausal account: an evaluative or modal adverb evaluates a *proposition*, so — the reasoning goes — there must be a clause inside the exception for it to evaluate. The reasoning overgenerates, as §8.2 shows in detail for Italian: both the evaluative *purtroppo* ‘unfortunately’ and the modal *possibilmente* ‘possibly’ appear inside uncontroversially relational projections — ordinary complex PPs, and the analytic exceptive *ad eccezione di* — which contain no clause at all. Their appearance in the exception therefore does not diagnose clausal structure; high-mobility adverbs simply interpose within the extended spine of a relational head and scope over the

exclusion relation. For Italian this dissolves the adverb argument, the modal sub-case included, and Seguin (2024)'s own examples use the factive evaluatives *purtroppo/evidentemente*. English *possibly* has a more rigid distribution than Italian *possibilmente*, and we leave open whether the English modal sub-case patterns identically; nothing in the analysis of *eccetto* turns on it.

8. Confronting the clausal diagnostics for *eccetto* (Seguin 2024)

Seguin (2024) is our most direct *opponent* for Italian, and she makes a specific and careful claim: that *eccetto* is *ambiguous* — clausal, with ellipsis, when its host is a universal, and phrasal, on an 'exclusive' reading, when its host is an existential, a numeral, or a *wh*-word. She supports the split with six diagnostics. One point of method frames everything that follows: wherever Seguin's judgments diverge from ours, the divergence is almost certainly a matter of *dialectal variation* — her consultants are speakers of northern varieties, ours of central Tuscan ones — and we treat it as such, not as a disagreement about the grammar of a single shared system (§10).

8.1 What Seguin claims, and the empirical premise

Seguin's thesis is stronger and more specific than a single ambiguity: she argues that Italian has *two homophonous* markers *eccetto*. With a universal-quantifier host, *eccetto* is a true exceptive, it is clausal, and it involves ellipsis, analysed with Vostrikova's (2021) conditional semantics. With an existential, numeral, or *wh*-host, *eccetto* is a distinct, *phrasal* marker with an *exclusive* meaning, base-generated in the high left periphery with the distribution of a Hanging Topic, and interpreted not by domain subtraction but by a discourse-level presupposition that the excluded entity is removed from the set of salient entities — Seguin's "anti-topic". The two are kept apart by a sharp distributional fact: the exceptive *eccetto*+UQ may sit in situ next to its host or in the periphery, whereas the exclusive *eccetto*+EQ/n/wh *must* be sentence-initial.

(35) Italian

a. *Ha incontrato tutti eccetto Luca.*

have.3SG met all except Luca

'S/he met everyone except Luca.' (exceptive; in situ, fine)

b. **Ha incontrato tre studenti eccetto Luca.*

have.3SG met three students except Luca (in situ with a numeral host: ungrammatical)

c. *Eccetto Luca, ha incontrato tre studenti.* (Seguin's northern exclusive)
 except Luca have.3SG met three students 'Setting aside Luca, s/he met three students.'
 (exclusive; Luca's status left open)

Our disagreement with Seguin has two parts, and it is essential to keep them apart. The first concerns the *exclusive eccetto* of (35c), and here the issue is empirical and dialectal. Seguin's data come from five speakers of northern varieties (Aosta Valley, Piedmont); our eight central Tuscan consultants (Florence, Prato, Pistoia; ages 25–54) do not accept the exclusive *eccetto* at all, even fronted, and express the 'setting aside' function with the additive/dual markers *a parte* and *oltre a* (§9). For these speakers there is no second, exclusive *eccetto*: there is one *eccetto*, the subtractive exceptive, and the discourse-removal function Seguin assigns to exclusive *eccetto* is the work of *a parte/oltre a*. We therefore do not contest Seguin's northern data; we observe that the exclusive *eccetto* is variety-specific, and that where it is absent the lexicon contains a single, uniformly subtractive *eccetto*. The second and central disagreement concerns the *exceptive eccetto*+UQ, which Seguin takes to be clausal. This is the claim that bears on our thesis, since we hold the true exceptive to be phrasal and relational. Two preliminary remarks frame the diagnostics that follow. First, Seguin's recourse to Vostrikova's conditional semantics for *eccetto*+UQ is *forced* by her clausal premise: she argues (her §3.2) that the simpler domain-subtraction-plus-Exh analysis cannot apply to *eccetto*+UQ precisely because, being biclausal, it would deny the marker compositional access to the quantifier's restriction. If *eccetto*+UQ is phrasal, as we argue on morphosyntactic grounds (§5), that obstacle disappears and the local Exh semantics of §3 applies directly — so the choice of conditional semantics is not independent evidence for clausality but a consequence of assuming it. Second, the diagnostics Seguin marshals for the clausality of *eccetto*+UQ — full-clause spell-out, multiple exceptions, non-DP complements, speaker-oriented adverbs, sprouting, and *same/different* — are exactly the diagnostics we take up, in §6 and in §8.2–§8.5, where we argue that none of them clearly establishes a clausal source and that two are undercut by Seguin's own observations.

8.2 Speaker-oriented adverbs

Seguin (2024), following Mayr & Vostrikova (2023), treats the availability of a speaker-oriented adverb inside the exception — *eccetto purtroppo/evidentemente Gianni* — as evidence that the host is

propositional, hence clausal. The inference does not go through, because the very same adverbs intervene inside structures that are uncontroversially relational and contain no clause.

(36) Italian

- a. *Sono venuti tutti, ad eccezione, purtroppo, di Gianni.*
 be.3PL come all to exception unfortunately of Gianni
 ‘Everyone came, with the unfortunate exception of Gianni.’
- b. *Sono arrivato prima, purtroppo, di te.*
 be.1SG arrived before unfortunately of you
 ‘Unfortunately, I arrived before you.’
- c. *Sono venuti tutti, ad eccezione possibilmente di Gianni.*
 be.3PL come all to exception possibly of Gianni
 ‘Everyone came, with the possible exception of Gianni.’
- d. *Vorrei che lo facessi prima possibilmente di mezzanotte.*
 want.1SG that it do.2SG before possibly of midnight
 ‘I’d like you to do it before midnight, if possible.’

In (36a) the evaluative *purtroppo* sits inside the analytic exceptive *ad eccezione di Gianni* — a transparently nominal/relational projection with no clause — and in (36b) inside an ordinary relational PP *prima di te*. Crucially, the same holds for the *modal* adverb on which Mayr & Vostrikova rest their case: *possibilmente* intervenes between the Axial Part and the lower relator in (36c–d), inside *ad eccezione di Gianni* and inside the complex temporal P *prima di mezzanotte*, neither of which contains (or could contain) a clause. The generalisation is simply that high-mobility adverbs may interpose within the extended spine of a relational head, scoping over the relation it expresses; their presence diagnoses nothing about clausal structure. Seguin's evidence here is in fact English — her (28b), **everyone except regrettably Mary came*, where the tightly grammaticalised *except* does resist the adverb (cf. §7) — but Italian shows this to be a fact about English *except* specifically, not about phrasal exceptives in general, since the uncontroversially phrasal *ad eccezione di* admits the adverb freely (36). This dissolves the diagnostic for evaluatives and for modal *possibly* alike, at least for Italian — and since Seguin's own examples use precisely the factive evaluatives *purtroppo* and *evidentemente*, the

adverb argument is, for the *eccetto* debate, fully answered. English *possibly* has a more rigid distribution and may behave differently; the Italian facts that bear on Seguin's claim are unambiguous.

8.3 Sprouting

Sprouting is the species of ellipsis in which the elided material has *no overt correlate* in the antecedent — as in *He's eating — What?*, where *what* recovers an object the antecedent never mentioned.

Following Stockwell & Wong (2020), Seguin observes that a *why*-fragment attached to an exceptive sentence is ambiguous: in *Everyone likes The Lord of the Rings, except John, but I don't know why*, the *why* can question either the whole generalisation (Reading 1) or, crucially, the proposition that *John does not like it* (Reading 2). Stockwell & Wong argue that Reading 2 is available only if the exceptive is clausal; Seguin reports that Italian *eccetto*+UQ permits Reading 2 (her 32) while *eccetto*+EQ/n does not (her 33), and takes this to confirm the clausal status of *eccetto*+UQ.

(37) Italian

Eccetto Luca, ha invitato tutti gli studenti, ma non so perché.

except Luca have.3SG invited all the students but not know.1SG why

'Except Luca, s/he invited all the students, but I don't know why.'

(Reading 2 available: 'why s/he did not invite Luca')

The diagnostic does not go through, and Seguin's own analysis shows why. Reading 2 questions the negative proposition 'Luca was not invited' — but that proposition is the negative *entailment* that any true exceptive carries, and that, on the distributed analysis, Exh derives at the propositional level (§3). It is therefore available to be questioned whether the exceptive is phrasal or clausal. Seguin in fact concedes precisely this mechanism: in her footnote on the EQ/n case she proposes that the absence of Reading 2 there follows *semantically*, from the fact that *perché* 'why' presupposes a reason for the negative proposition while *eccetto*+EQ/n, lacking a negative entailment, fails to supply one. Once granted, this explanation applies equally to the UQ case: *eccetto*+UQ permits Reading 2 because it *has* the negative entailment, not because it is clausal. The availability of Reading 2 thus tracks the negative entailment — which §3 derives for any true exceptive — and not clausal structure. An independent theory of sprouting predicts the same: on the *Question-Under-Discussion* approach (Griffiths 2019), the antecedent for a sprout need not be an isomorphic clause but can be the implicit question raised by

the assertion, here *why didn't s/he invite Luca?*, raised by the derived entailment. The response is strong, and it rests in part on Seguin's own footnote.

8.4 same/different

The adjective *diverso* 'different' has two readings. On the *external* reading it means different from some contextually salient thing; on the *internal* (reciprocal, or "Q-bound") reading, available only when a distributive quantifier binds the indefinite, it means different *from one another* (Beck 2000).

(38) Italian

a. *Tutti gli studenti hanno portato una torta diversa.*

all the students have.3PL brought a cake different

'All the students brought a different cake.' (internal reading available)

b. *??Tre studenti hanno portato una torta diversa.* (on the internal reading)

three students have.3PL brought a cake different

'Three students brought a different cake.'

c. *Tutti gli studenti eccetto Nicole hanno letto un libro diverso.*

all the students except Nicole have.3PL read a book different

'All the students except Nicole read a different book.' (internal reading available)

Seguin uses the availability of the internal reading as a clausal diagnostic: a phrasal exceptive, she holds, leaves it available, whereas her *eccetto*+UQ — *Eccetto Nicole, tutti gli studenti hanno letto un libro diverso* (her 37), with *eccetto* fronted — permits only the external reading, which she takes to confirm a clausal structure. The diagnostic does not bear the weight, for three reasons of increasing depth. First, for the *eccetto*+EQ/n case Seguin herself withdraws it: she shows (her 40, our 38a–b) that the internal reading is independently unavailable with existential and numeral hosts even with no exceptive present, since non-universal quantifiers do not license it, and concludes that the test cannot diagnose the structure of *eccetto*+EQ/n. We agree; the effect is the host's, not the exceptive's. Second, with a universal host the internal reading *survives* when *eccetto* is left adjacent to its associate (38c): in *tutti gli studenti eccetto Nicole hanno letto un libro diverso* one readily gets the reading on which each non-expected student read a book different from the others' — Gianni *The Gambler*, Maria *a Simenon*, and so on — while Nicole, the exception, falls outside the comparison. Since *eccetto*+UQ occurs adjacent as well as fronted (her own 16a), the external-only judgment on her (37) is an artefact of

fronting the exceptive, not a reflex of clausal structure, and the adjacent (38c) patterns with the phrasal English *every baker except Nicky baked a different cake*, which Seguin marks as ambiguous. Third, and most fundamentally, it is doubtful that the internal/external contrast diagnoses narrow-syntactic structure at all. Whether the reciprocal, Q-bound reading is available is a delicate matter of how distributivity is resolved at the conceptual–intentional interface — sensitive to information structure, plausibility, and the position of the associate — and a contrast of that kind is not the sort of thing one expects to track a phrasal-versus-clausal distinction in the narrow syntax. On any of the three counts the *same/different* facts are inconclusive, and they are not, as they stand, an argument for a clausal *eccetto*+UQ.

8.5 *Spell-out, and a balance*

Two of Seguin's diagnostics — multiple exceptions and the category of the complement — were treated in §6.2 and §6.1, respectively. The last is *spell-out*: Seguin observes that with *eccetto*+UQ the full clause can be pronounced — *Ha invitato tutti gli studenti, eccetto non ha invitato Luca* 'S/he invited all the students, except s/he did not invite Luca' (her 22a) — which she finds grammatical though redundant, and reads as evidence of an underlying clause; with *eccetto*+EQ/n the full clause cannot be pronounced (her 22b).

(39) Italian

a. %*Ha invitato tutti gli studenti, eccetto non ha invitato Luca.*

have.3SG invited all the students except not have.3SG invited Luca

(Seguin's northern speakers: redundant / grammatical; our Tuscan consultants: ungrammatical)

b. *Maria è più alta di Anna.* / **Maria è più alta di Anna è alta.*

Maria is more tall of Anna / Maria is more tall of Anna is tall

'Maria is taller than Anna.'

Two remarks. First, the judgment in (39a) is sharply split by variety: Seguin's northern speakers report mere redundancy, whereas our central consultants reject the spelled-out clause outright. The spell-out facts are therefore variety-specific, and for the central varieties on which our argument rests they give no support to an underlying clause — the exceptive *eccetto*+UQ there simply has no full-clause counterpart. Second, spell-out is in any case a weak diagnostic, because the relation between pronounceability and underlying structure is loose in both directions: *obligatory* ellipsis is

independently attested — the comparative in (39b) can never be spelled out as ...*di Anna è alta*, though a two-degree comparison is un-controversially present — so non-pronounceability does not entail the absence of structure; and a redundant full clause, where one is available, may be an adversative afterthought rather than the exceptive's source. We therefore rest nothing on spell-out, in either direction.

Taking §8 as a whole: the *exclusive eccetto* on which Seguin's two-marker picture rests is dialectally restricted, and absent in the central varieties, where its 'setting aside' function is carried by *a parte/oltre a* (§8.1, §9). As for the *exceptive eccetto*+UQ, the diagnostics offered for its clausality do not establish it: the speaker-adverb facts hold inside relational projections (§8.2); the sprouting facts track the negative entailment, by Seguin's own footnote (§8.3); the *same/different* facts are confounded by host type for EQ/n on Seguin's own showing, are an artefact of fronting for UQ, and arguably do not probe syntactic structure at all (§8.4); the multiple-exception and complement-category facts were handled in §6; and spell-out is variety-specific and weak (§8.5). For the *eccetto* debate, then, none of the diagnostics forces a clausal source, and the morphosyntax of §5 points the other way.

9. Additives versus subtractives

Part of what has made the Quantifier Constraint and the 'exclusive' readings look puzzling is that the Italian lexicon has been read as containing a single, polyfunctional exceptive. It does not. Once we separate the subtractive markers from the *additive* ones, both puzzles ease. Italian *a parte* 'apart from' and *oltre a* 'besides' are additive, not subtractive: they do not enforce containment, and they combine freely with existential and negative-polarity hosts, precisely where the subtractive markers are barred.

(40) Italian

- a. *Qualche ragazzo, a parte Gianni, ha superato l'esame.*
 some boy apart Gianni has passed the.exam
 'Some boy, apart from Gianni, passed the exam.'
- b. *Non ho visto nessuno, a parte Gianni.*
 not have.1SG seen nobody apart Gianni
 'I haven't seen anybody, apart from Gianni.'

The subtractive *tranne/eccetto* are ungrammatical in exactly these frames (**qualche ragazzo tranne Gianni*), and §3.2 explains why: subtraction needs a saturated domain and feeds Exh, which is vacuous with an existential. Additives impose no such requirement, because they do not subtract — they simply adjoin an extra element. Additives are ordinary relational adjuncts computing adjacency, while subtractives require a universal or negative restriction — and it lets us dispense with a special Hanging-Topic derivation for an ‘exclusive *eccetto*’ (Seguin 2024). We thus locate the exclusive/additive function in *a parte/oltre a* and treat *eccetto* as uniformly subtractive, cohering with §8.1. In the terms of §1, additives are a *third* device, neither the true exceptive nor its Boolean understudy.

The additive class itself subdivides, and the contrast with subtractives sharpens once we add the cardinal-additive *più* ‘plus’, which has not figured in earlier work on Italian exception. Where *a parte* and *oltre a* combine with existential and negative hosts (40), *più* is the mirror image of the subtractive marker in its host requirements: fine with cardinals, anomalous with universals and with negatives.

(41) Italian

- a. *Ho visto dodici adulti più Marco / più due.*
have.1SG seen twelve adults plus Marco / plus two
‘I saw twelve adults plus Marco / plus two.’
- b. *#Ho visto tutti più Marco.*
have.1SG seen all plus Marco
‘#I saw everyone plus Marco.’
- c. *#Non ho visto nessuno più Marco.*
not have.1SG seen nobody plus Marco
‘#I saw nobody plus Marco.’

The logic behind (41) is the mirror of the Quantifier Constraint. A universal already exhausts its domain, so there is nothing for an additive to *add* to (41b); a negative quantifier likewise gives the additive no positive base to extend (41c). A subtractive, by contrast, *requires* exactly such a saturated domain, in order to draw a boundary within it (§3.2). The two markers thus impose complementary conditions — *più* needs a non-maximal count, *tranne* a maximal one — which is just what we expect if both are relational heads computing inclusion over a domain, but in opposite directions (addition to it versus subtraction from it), and not what we expect if either were a propositional coordinator.

Comitative *con* is distinct again: *Ho visto tutti con Marco* ‘I saw everyone with Marco’ is acceptable on

the accompaniment reading, preferentially with Marco *outside* the *tutti* set, because *con* computes inverse inclusion (§4.2) rather than addition or subtraction. The three-way contrast among subtractive *tranne*, additive *più*, and comitative *con* is a contrast among *directions of a single inclusion relation*, and it is invisible to any analysis that treats the exceptive as clausal coordination.

10. The typology of exception and the variation it predicts

10.1 The parameter

The UG hypothesis reduces the apparent diversity of exceptive constructions to a single building device with a small space of settings. UG supplies one exceptive skeleton — the Double-Relator configuration [Figure [p_upper [AxP/RelN [p_lower [Ground]]]]], whose head is a relational noun / Axial Part — and grammars vary along three dimensions.

- (i) *Grammaticalisation of the Axial Part.* The head may be realised analytically, with the relational noun and one or both relators overt (Italian *ad eccezione di*, Persian *be joz-e*, English *with the exception of*), or it may grammaticalise into a monomorphemic marker that spells out the whole skeleton and licenses null relators (Italian *tranne*, *eccetto*; Russian *krome*; Japanese *igai*). Grammaticalisation is a cline, not a switch, and one language typically hosts forms at several points along it (Heine and Kuteva 2002).
- (ii) *Realisation of the lower relator.* With a DP Ground the lower relator may be an overt genitive case-marker or adposition (Italian *di*, Persian *Ezafe -e*, Russian genitive) or null (Italian *tranne* Ø *Gianni*). With a non-DP Ground a linker is recruited to satisfy nominal selection (Italian *che*, Japanese *koto* / adnominal *-na*).
- (iii) *Availability of a clausal-source competitor.* Independently of the relational device, a language may also approximate exception with the Boolean periphrasis (coordinator + negation); and — the macroparametric point — its exceptive markers may *additionally* license a genuine clausal/coordinating parse. Where they do, a subject-correlated remnant surfaces with nominative case (Spanish *excepto yo*); where they do not, the Ground is uniformly oblique (Italian *tranne me*).

Only (iii) is properly a binary macroparameter; (i) and (ii) are dimensions of how one and the same head is spelled out. The typology of exception is thus the typology of how a single relational head is realised, plus whether a Boolean/clausal competitor is recruited alongside it. Table 1 summarises the markers discussed below against these dimensions.

Marker	Transparent skeleton	Lower relator on DP Ground	Clausal-source competitor
It. <i>ad eccezione di</i>	overt (RelN + <i>a</i> + <i>di</i>)	<i>di</i> (genitive)	no
It. <i>tranne, eccetto</i>	grammaticalised	null; oblique on pronoun	no (oblique)
Sp. <i>excepto, salvo</i>	grammaticalised	—	yes (nominative remnant)
Russ. <i>krome</i>	grammaticalised	genitive	no
Pers. <i>be joz-e</i>	overt (<i>be</i> + <i>joz</i> + EZ)	Ezafe <i>-e</i>	no
Jpn. <i>igai</i>	grammaticalised (postp.)	nominaliser <i>koto/-na</i>	no

Table 1. Exceptive markers by realisation of the relational head and availability of a clausal-source competitor.

10.2 Microvariation: the Italian–Spanish macro split and Italian-internal micro-variation

We argue that the analytic exceptive — a relational noun flanked by an upper and a lower relator — is the Romance default, and the monomorphemic markers are its diachronic compression: Italian *ad eccezione di*, *all'infuori di* alongside *tranne* < *tra* *ne* ‘extract from it’, *eccetto* < *exceptum* ‘taken out’, *fuorché* < *fuori* ‘outside’ + *che*; Spanish *a excepción de* alongside *salvo* < *salvum* and *excepto* < *exceptum*. The morphology, synchronic and diachronic, points to a relational-noun source and never to a coordinator, consistent with the device of §10.1.

The two languages then diverge on macroparameter (iii), and the divergence is visible in case. Italian markers are uniformly relational: a subject-correlated remnant is obligatorily oblique, with no nominative parse in any register (§5.1). Spanish admits, alongside the relational realisation, a clausal/coordinating parse, and a subject-correlated remnant accordingly surfaces in the nominative. The minimal pair isolates the split.

(42) Italian / Spanish

- a. *Hanno nuotato tutti tranne me / *??tranne io.*
have.3PL swam all except me.OBL / except I.NOM
'Everyone swam except me.'
- b. *Nadaron todos excepto yo / ??excepto mí* (standard).
swim.PST.3PL all except I.NOM / except me.OBL
'Everyone swam except me.'

Same construction, same host, opposite case on the exception. Under case-matching (Merchant 2004) the Spanish nominative (42b) is read off an elided finite T, exactly as a clausal source predicts; the Italian oblique (42a) is read off the lower relator, exactly as a relational head predicts. This is macro-variation of the cleanest kind — a single typological switch with a single morphological diagnostic — and it places Spanish *excepto/salvo* on the clausal-capable side and Italian *tranne/eccetto* on the relational side, in line with Pérez-Jiménez & Moreno-Quibén (2012) and Potsdam & Polinsky (2019). Within Italian, the same single device varies in *reach* rather than in *category*. Northern varieties (Seguin's 2024 consultants) extend *eccetto* to an exclusive use with existential and numeral hosts; central Tuscan varieties (§8.1) restrict *eccetto* to subtraction and discharge the exclusive/additive function onto *a parte/oltre a* (§9). On the present account this is variation in the *distribution of one relational marker*, not a difference between clausal and phrasal structure — precisely the low-level variation that a UG account of a single device, parameterised in its degree of grammaticalisation, leads us to expect.

10.3 The crosslinguistic skeleton

Beyond Romance, the prediction is that where the relators are *not* grammaticalised away the skeleton should be overt, and that across unrelated families the true exceptive should be built on a relational-noun / adpositional base rather than on clausal coordination. The prediction is borne out.

Persian, a language for which we have native informants, provides a striking morphological confirmation of this architecture. To express exception, Persian employs the complex adposition *be joz(-e)* 'except'. Crucially, the element *joz* is a direct borrowing from Arabic *juz*, which literally translates to 'part' or 'portion' — the ultimate etymological fossil of an Axial Part. The construction lays the Double-Relator skeleton bare: *be* 'to/at' is the spatial preposition acting as the higher relator,

joz ‘part’ is the literal embodiment of the Axial Part, and the Ezafe suffix *-e* acts as the lower relator linking the Axial Part to the nominal Ground DP (Samiian 1983; Ghomeshi 1997).

(43) Persian

[p_upper *be* [AxP *joz* [p_lower *-e* [Ground man]]]]

to part -EZ me

‘Except me’ (lit. ‘to the part of me’)

Because *be joz-e* is a relational head, it computes subtraction locally over a nominal domain. We thus predict that it must enforce containment, unlike a Boolean periphrasis. This is exactly what we find, explicitly replicating the Italian penguin contrast of (2) in Persian:

(44) Persian

a. *Hame-ye pestāndār-ān ro did-am, be joz-(e) dolfīn-hā.*

all-EZ mammal-PL DOM see.PST-1SG to part-EZ dolphin-PL

‘I saw all the mammals, except the dolphins.’

b. *#Hame-ye pestāndār-ān ro did-am, be joz-(e) panguan-hā.*

all-EZ mammal-PL DOM see.PST-1SG to part-EZ penguin-PL

‘#I saw all the mammals except the penguins.’ (Relational exceptive)

c. *Hame-ye pestāndār-ān ro did-am, ammā panguan-hā ro na.*

all-EZ mammal-PL DOM see.PST-1SG but penguin-PL DOM not

‘I saw all the mammals, but not the penguins.’ (Boolean periphrasis)

The anomaly of (44b) demonstrates that *be joz-e* cannot be a Boolean periphrasis: the relational head attempts to subtract penguins from the nominal restriction of mammals, resulting in an undefined operation. Conversely, when a true Boolean strategy is used, joining two independent propositions with the coordinator *ammā* ‘but’ and negation *na* (44c), the sentence is perfectly acceptable, as no containment is enforced. Therefore, *be joz-e* belongs to the class of true exceptives. Further morphosyntactic evidence rules out a clausal coordination analysis for *be joz-e*. By Pantcheva’s (2006) diagnostics, *joz* patterns with Axial-Part-hosted adpositions, optionally taking the Ezafe linker to combine with a nominal Ground (Perry 2007). Furthermore, when the Ground of *be joz* genuinely is a clause, Persian relies on the exact same nominalising strategy we observed for Italian (§6.3): it

obligatorily recruits a *nominal* shell.⁵ To embed a clause, Persian uses *be joz in-ke* ('to the part of this-that'), where the demonstrative *in* acts as the nominal Ground that satisfies the Axial Part's selectional requirements, and the complementizer *ke* introduces the clause. Thus, even when a clause is involved, it is embedded under a nominal-selecting relational skeleton, leaving no room for a Boolean clausal coordination analysis.

Another language that shows a clear case for a relational exceptive is Russian. This language uses the adposition *krome*, which assigns genitive to its Ground and bars both clausal remnants and multiple exceptions (Potsdam & Polinsky 2019).

(45) Russian

Vse det-i za-plaka-l-i, krome Maš-i.

all child-PL INCH-cry-PST-PL except Masha-GEN

'All the children started crying, except Masha.'

The overt genitive is the lower relator spelled out, with the Axial Part grammaticalised and no clausal competitor available — the mirror of Italian *tranne* with an overt rather than null *di*.

Finally, Japanese provides the sharpest evidence that the exceptive head is inherently adpositional and nominal-selecting, not a boolean coordinator. As Polinsky, Kurokami, and Potsdam (2024: 290–292) demonstrate, the exceptive marker *igai* ('outside, except') is a postposition. When its Ground is propositional, it cannot coordinate a finite clause; rather, it forces the clause to be nominalised, obligatorily requiring either the nominaliser *koto* (their ex. 38) or the adnominal copula *-na* against the finite *-da* (their ex. 40).

(46) Japanese

Taroo-ga kuru-koto-igai-wa kii-te-nai.

Taro-nom come-NMLZ-except-top hear-ger-neg.prs

'I was not informed about anything except that Taro is coming.' (Polinsky et al. 2024: 291)

⁵ Note that Persian possesses a genuine clausal/Boolean coordinator, *magar* ('unless/but'), which strictly and categorically rejects the Ezafe (*magar man / *magar-e man*), precisely because the Ezafe is a nominal/adpositional linker, not a clausal one. The fact that *joz* licenses the Ezafe—even when optionally dropped—is the unambiguous morphological signature of a relational head taking a nominal complement.

(47) Japanese

Dezain-ga totemo kanso{ -da / -na}-igai-wa monku.no.tuke.dokoro-ga nai.*

design-nom very simple-{COP.FIN /ADN}-except-top place.to.complain.about-nom neg.prs

‘Except for the design being very simple, there is nothing to complain about.’

(Adapted from Polinsky et al. 2024: 292)

The obligatory nominaliser *koto* and the adnominal morphology *-na* act as the functional analogues of Italian *che*-insertion (§5.3, §6.3): generalized linkers dressing a non-nominal Ground to satisfy the postposition’s nominal selection. A Boolean coordinator adjoining full CPs would predict unmodified finite complementation (*-da*), which is sharply ungrammatical. While Polinsky et al. (2024) propose a clausal ellipsis derivation for Japanese “free exceptives”, their underlying structural analysis ([PP [NP [CP . . .] (*koto*)] *igai*], p. 292) perfectly aligns with our Universal Grammar hypothesis: the dedicated exceptive device remains a relational, adpositional head that selects a nominal projection. Furthermore, Polinsky et al. explicitly document that Japanese free exceptives fail the core diagnostics for clausal ellipsis: they lack the sluicing ambiguity expected of elided clauses (2024: 287, ex. 31), and they freely allow the internal reading of *tigau* ‘different’ (2024: 289, ex. 36), which is a hallmark of phrasal, not clausal, exceptives. This confirms that there is no empirical need to stipulate TP-deletion inside a nominalized CP to derive exception; a phrasal relational head captures the data directly.⁶

11. Discussion and conclusion

We have argued that Universal Grammar provides one dedicated strategy for exception — a relational head, an Axial Part in a Double-Relator configuration, projecting a PP — and that languages either grammaticalise it (Italian *tranne*, *eccetto*, *salvo*; English *except*) or approximate exception with a Boolean coordinator plus negation (*ma non*, *but not*) that is not a true exceptive. Containment is the diagnostic that separates them: it defines membership in the exceptive class, and because the Boolean periphrasis fails it, any containment-enforcing marker is forced onto the relational analysis. The relational head, feeding the distributed semantics of subtraction plus exhaustification, derives the defining cluster — containment, the Quantifier Constraint, and the inference flip — with no silent

⁶ A methodological caveat frames the whole survey, and it is the same point that organised the paper. Descriptive grammars routinely conflate true exceptives with adversative coordinators (‘but’, ‘and not’), and the diagnostic that separates them is precisely containment: the Boolean periphrasis fails it, the relational exceptive enforces it. Apparent ‘clausal exceptives’ in a reference grammar are, on inspection, frequently the Boolean periphrasis misclassified — which is why containment, and not surface clausality, is the right crosslinguistic probe.

clausal structure (§3), and the morphosyntax of the markers that enforce that cluster is adpositional, not coordinating (§5, §7). The two legs of the argument, the semantic and the morphosyntactic, converge. We have been deliberate about the limits of the claim, because the value of the position lies as much in what it does not assert as in what it does. Against the Boolean understudy the case is decisive (§2.1). Against the conditional clausal-ellipsis analysis (Vostrikova 2019; 2021; Seguin 2024) the case is comparative and, we believe, favourable, but it is not a refutation: that analysis derives the meaning, and the most resilient pro-clausal diagnostic — speaker-oriented adverbs in the exception (§7, §8.2) — we have argued does not in fact diagnose clausal structure, since both evaluative and modal adverbs occur inside uncontroversially relational projections such as the analytic *ad eccezione possibilmente di Gianni* and the temporal *prima possibilmente di mezzanotte*. Our claim is therefore not that a clausal analysis of exception is impossible — the dichotomy itself reserves a clausal/coordinating route for the Boolean periphrasis, Spanish exceptive remnants carry nominative as a clausal source predicts, and genuine CP Grounds exist (§6.3, §6.4, §7) — but that, where a language has a transparent complex P that enforces containment, a clausal derivation with TP-ellipsis is superfluous and is excluded by economy, and that clausal structure appears only when the Ground is itself a clause. The resulting position is narrower than ‘no exceptive is ever clausal’, and more defensible for it.

It is also, by design, a theory of variation: the same relational device, parameterised in its degree of grammaticalisation and in whether a clausal-source competitor is available, predicts the macro-variation between Spanish and Italian and the micro-variation between northern and Tuscan Italian. The burden shifts, as minimalist economy recommends, from invisible syntax to a transparent syntax–semantics interface, and the typology of exception becomes the typology of a single relational head and its Boolean understudy.

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